

process. The period after the Candidates was tough for me because I had given everything to it and didn't get the results I wanted. I felt empty and didn't know what to do next. What was my next goal? I had dedicated myself entirely to the Candidates — so what now? I went through a bit of an existential crisis.

How did you overcome that phase?

For about a month after the Candidates, I was completely burnt out. Then I moved from Nashik to Mumbai. I felt that a change in environment and being around friends would help. I also eased off my chess preparation for a while. It took two to three months to find my rhythm again.

You turned 30 recently. Given that chess is a sport increasingly dominated by younger players, how are you handling it?

It's something that lingers in the back of my mind. I've realised that the best way to deal with it is to accept that I'm 30 and make decisions

accordingly. The way I eat has changed, and my sleep pattern has changed. If I tried living as though I were still 18, it wouldn't work.

At first, it wasn't easy, but I've managed to reset my goals, and I feel I'm getting a better grasp on things now. Also, I met my fiancée around this time, so turning 30 hasn't been bad.

You mentioned the FIDE Grand Swiss title. Do you consider that the best victory of your career?

Absolutely. It was an extremely strong field, and I lost my first-round game. I'm very proud to bounce back and win what's regarded as the strongest open tournament. I also remember making some incredibly aggressive moves

— quite unlike my usual style. I was bold and fearless, and I loved that.

You were one of the first Indian chess players to explore streaming. What led you to that decision?

I had always wanted to try it, but until 2017-18, the internet where I lived wasn't good enough for streaming. Then I moved houses, and at the same time, the pandemic hit. I can't sit idle — I'm a workaholic, or at least I used to be.

Engaging with an audience comes naturally to me, and I'm good at chess, so I combined the two. The timing was perfect as well, with so many people streaming and consuming content. Many who had drifted away from chess started watching it again during the pandemic.

Chess, like any professional sport, has rivalries, but you've struck up a strong friendship with fellow Super GM Anish Giri. It's probably the best 'bromance' in the chess world. How did it start, and what is the foundation of your friendship beyond chess?

